

Christianity Reading and Questions

Answer key for the graphic organizer. For Jonathan, to work through with Alex.

The assignment is a one page graphic organizer with eight boxes, and the boxes are small. **The blue block in each one is sized to fit**, roughly 45 to 50 words, about eight or nine handwritten lines. Everything under "Background" is context for you, not for copying, so you can answer him when he asks why. He should still put the blue text in his own words where he can.

1 Early Christians

Who were they and what did they believe?

WRITE THIS · 48 WORDS

Early Christians were Jews living under Roman rule who were waiting for a messiah, meaning a savior. They believed they had found him in Jesus of Nazareth. They believed Jesus was the son of God, born to the virgin Mary, and was the deliverer promised in the Torah.

BACKGROUND, FOR YOU

They were Jews living under Roman occupation, in what is today Israel. They were looking for a **messiah**, which means a savior or deliverer, and they believed they had found him in Jesus of Nazareth, who was himself Jewish.

They believed his mother Mary was a virgin and that he was the son of God. The title **Christ** comes from the Hebrew word for messiah. They saw Jesus as the fulfillment of the promise of a heavenly deliverer already written in the Jewish Torah.

2 Christ and Baptism, main idea

Select a portion of text that best summarizes why Christians celebrate Christmas. Place it in quotation marks.

WRITE THIS · 30 WORDS

"Jesus's immaculate conception and birth signifies to Christians that while divine by nature, God's son, took on an earthly form in order to save his followers from sin, or wrongdoing."

BACKGROUND, FOR YOU

This box wants a direct quote, not a summary, so the quote above *is* the answer. It is the right one because it explains *why* the birth matters rather than just saying Christmas happens in December.

If that is too long to fit, he can cut the middle with an ellipsis and it still answers the question: *"Jesus's ... birth signifies to Christians that ... God's son, took on an earthly form in order to save his followers from sin."*

3 Summarize the crucifixion and resurrection of Jesus

WRITE THIS · 49 WORDS

Jewish leaders saw Jesus as a threat and charged him with blasphemy. The Roman governor Pontius Pilate had him crucified between two criminals. Christians believe he died to take on the sins of mankind. Three days later his tomb was empty. They believe he rose and ascended to heaven.

BACKGROUND, FOR YOU

As Jesus grew more popular, the Jewish leadership grew hostile. They worried he had come to overthrow the Roman government, which threatened their own power.

At Passover, a crowd waved palm branches as Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey. Christians read this as him fulfilling his role as Messiah. The leadership treated it as **heresy**, an opinion at odds with religious teaching, and charged him with **blasphemy**, profaning the name of God.

Pilate could not calm the crowd, so he sentenced Jesus to death on a cross. Christians believe this death was necessary so he could take on the sins of mankind. His followers sealed his body in a tomb and could not return for three days because of Passover. When they did, it was empty.

4 Sketch: the New and Old Testament

Draw a quick picture of your understanding.

LABEL THE DRAWING

- Old Testament = the Jewish Torah
- New Testament = 4 Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John) + letters
- Both together = the Christian Bible

BACKGROUND, FOR YOU

Draw one Bible split into two halves and label them. **Epistles** are letters written by early church leaders.

Gospels means good news. **Testament** means covenant.

The grading here is whether the two halves and their contents are right, not the quality of the drawing. A stick figure version is fine.

5 Select a portion of text that you find interesting

This one is genuinely his. It asks what *he* finds interesting, so there is no right answer and picking one for him removes the only part of the sheet that is actually his.

If he stalls, these tend to catch people: that 31.5 percent of the world is Christian and over 2.2 billion people; the selling of **indulgences**, money paid to cover sins; or Henry VIII founding an entire church because the pope would not let him divorce.

6 Summarize the Spread of Christianity section

WRITE THIS · 45 WORDS

After Jesus died, the Romans destroyed Jerusalem and scattered its people, which spread Christianity around the Mediterranean. Christians spread the good news wherever they went but were persecuted. In 313 CE the emperor Constantine converted and made it legal. His council wrote the Nicene Creed.

BACKGROUND, FOR YOU

Wherever Christians went they **evangelized**, meaning they spread the "good news" of Christ, but they were also persecuted. Along with Jews, they were blamed for harm and misfortune.

Constantine's conversion was partly a political move to win the favor of Christians. To keep the faith consistent he assembled a council to write a statement of faith, the **Nicene Creed**, which says God is three persons, the holy trinity: the Father who is creator, the Son who is Christ, and the Holy Spirit.

7 Sketch: the Splitting of the Church

Draw a quick picture of your understanding.

LABEL THE DRAWING

- Great Schism (empire splits) → Orthodox Church (East) + Roman Catholic Church (West)
- Reformation → Luther (Germany), Calvin (France), Henry VIII (England)
- Henry VIII → Church of England, also called Anglican or Episcopal

BACKGROUND, FOR YOU

A branching tree is the clearest way to draw this. Two separate splits, in order.

Luther objected to **indulgences**, money paid to cover sins, and translated the Bible into German so people could read it themselves. **Calvin** taught **predestination**, that God has already determined who is saved. **Henry VIII** broke away after the pope refused to let him divorce.

8 Churches and Rites

Read the section, look at the graphic titled "Major Branches of Christianity," and summarize your understanding.

WRITE THIS · 44 WORDS

The denomination decides what a church looks like. Catholic churches are elaborate, Protestant ones plainer. Inside are pews, an altar where the sermon is given, and sometimes a baptism font. Rites include baptism and the Eucharist, bread and wine representing Christ's body and blood.

BACKGROUND, FOR YOU

On festivals: besides Christmas, some churches mark the birth or death of **martyrs**, people killed because of their faith. **Easter** is celebrated each spring, commemorates the death and resurrection of Christ, and is seen as a time of renewal of faith.

Denomination or sect means a branch of the religion. A **rite** is a religious ceremony. **Protestant** just means non-Catholic.

There is a factual error in the handout itself. The reading calls Queen Elizabeth I Henry VIII's "granddaughter." She was his **daughter**, by Anne Boleyn. Best to answer it the way the sheet says and raise it with Mr. Flores separately, rather than putting Alex in the middle of it.

One gap. Box 8 tells him to look at a graphic titled "Major Branches of Christianity." That is a picture, not text, so it did not come through when I read the PDF and I have not seen it. Have him read it off his own printed copy. From the surrounding text it most likely shows the Orthodox, Roman Catholic and Protestant branches.

Built from the text of "Alexander Shroyer - Christianity Reading Student.pdf" in Alex's Google Drive, pulled 20 September 2026. Boxes 4, 5 and 7 have no blue block on purpose: two are drawings and one asks for his own opinion.